



CHOOSING STRUCTURED FILES OR RAG

Structured files or RAG?

Choose the lightest architecture that reliably solves the knowledge problem you actually have.



02 / 8

Start with the source, not the retrieval layer

If the knowledge is duplicated, stale or unnamed, a more sophisticated search layer will retrieve the same disorder faster.





Structured files win when the corpus is bounded

A few dozen to a few hundred curated documents can stay legible to both people and agents.





04 / 8

They win when relationships matter

Rules can link to definitions, playbooks and proof. An agent can follow the same reasoning path as a careful operator.





05 / 8

They win when change must be immediate

Edit the source file and the
agent sees the current version.
No chunking or embedding
refresh is required.





06 / 8

RAG wins when scale and search complexity dominate

Large, heterogeneous corpora and high-volume semantic discovery can justify dedicated retrieval infrastructure.





07 / 8

The useful answer may be both

Keep an authoritative structured source, then add retrieval where the corpus and use case genuinely demand it.





08 / 8

Architecture should follow the problem

Do not buy complexity as a
substitute for information
design.

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